The Memo

DAILY INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

TUESDAY, JANUARY 6, 2026

NO. 0-58

Executive Summary

[Iran war] US bunker-busters hit Natanz nuclear site on Day 22. Iran fires missiles at Diego Garcia, exceeding known range. See Global Conflict Monitor.

[Hormuz escalation] Pentagon destroys Iranian coastal facilities threatening Strait. 2,000+ Marines deploying as White House weighs seizing Kharg Island. See World Affairs.

[Rate shock] Markets price 75% chance of Fed hike by September. US 10-year yield surges 41bp in three weeks to 4.38%. See Credit, Rates & Currencies.

[UK fiscal stress] UK 10-year gilt breaches 5% — highest since the financial crisis. Costs Reeves an estimated £3B in fiscal headroom. See Credit, Rates & Currencies.

[ECB pivot] German Bund yield hits 3.025%. Barclays and J.P. Morgan forecast ECB 25bp hike in June. April move priced at 60%. See Economic & Business Intelligence.

[Oil physical premium] Some refined products now trading above $200/barrel. Physical premiums widening sharply over futures. See Economic & Business Intelligence.

[Private credit cracks] Blackstone's $83B BCRED posts first monthly loss since 2022. Private credit defaults up 78% YoY per Morningstar DBRS. See IPO & Exit Climate.

[AI hiring surge] OpenAI plans to nearly double headcount to 8,000. PE firms offer AI labs a $14B shortcut to enterprise deployment. See AI & Technology.

[Data center mega-bet] SoftBank's Son unveils $500B single-campus Ohio data center plan powered by gas plants. See Real Estate & Property.

[Ukraine offensive] Ukraine launches operations after Musk cuts Russian forces' Starlink access. Russian commanders lose battlefield connectivity. See Global Conflict Monitor.

Credit, Rates & Currencies

DAY 2 **[Waller — 'Protracted Conflict' Means Oil Stays High, But Cuts Possible Later]** *Waller had planned to vote for a cut before Iran changed the calculus.* Now says weak job market may still warrant cuts later this year. Bowman separately maintained three-cut projection. FOMC divergence growing. Previously: Waller intended to vote for a cut on weak February jobs data. Iran war's inflation threat convinced him to hold. Waller-Bowman split reveals deep FOMC divide. Market sides with hawks at 75% hike probability by September. Resolution awaits April CPI.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 3 **[Oil Eases From $120 Spike — Brent Near $109, WTI High $90s as US Opens Supply Taps]** *WTI dropped from $119 peak; Brent fell 5% to ~$100 last week.* SPR release, Iranian tanker passage, and 'winding down' rhetoric drove further pullback. IEA warns Gulf field recovery could take 6+ months. Some refined products trading above $200/bbl physically. Previously: Netanyahu signaled restraint after Trump rebuke. WTI dropped from $119 peak. Brent fell 5% to $100. Physical premiums above $200 signal severe downstream tightness. SPR releases are a straw replacing a water main. Brent likely $105–115 absent ceasefire.

Sources: Bloomberg; OilPrice; Bloomberg

DAY 3 **[Fed Cut Bets Fully Erased — Traders Now Price Hikes Through Mid-2027]** *Two-year yields jumped above the policy rate last week as oil hit $119.* CME FedWatch shows no easing priced until mid-2027. BofA still forecasts two cuts but the market has moved decisively against them. Previously: Traders had erased all cut expectations. Two-year yields jumped above the policy rate as oil hit $119. Cut-to-hike pivot in under three weeks is historically rare. Duration-long positions built on 2025 easing consensus are underwater. Reversal requires a ceasefire.

Sources: Decrypt †; Bloomberg

Global Conflict Monitor

MIDDLE EAST

[US-Israel War on Iran — Day 22] ▲ **Escalating**

Parties: United States, Israel vs. Iran (IRGC, Hezbollah proxies)

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: US bunker-buster bombs struck Natanz nuclear enrichment facility. No radioactive leakage reported. Iran launched ballistic missiles at Diego Garcia, exceeding known range. Cluster-warhead missiles hit Israel; debris landed near Temple Mount. Attacks targeted UAE, Kuwait, and Saudi Arabia. Hormuz remains closed, blocking ~20% of global oil and LNG. Iran offered Japan transit through Hormuz. Trump floated 'winding down' while deploying thousands more Marines via USS Boxer. UK approved US use of British bases. Iraq declared force majeure on all foreign-operated oilfields. Kataib Hezbollah agreed to a temporary pause in attacks on the US Embassy in Baghdad.

Risk Assessment: Week four shows escalatory dynamics despite Trump's rhetorical pivot. Hormuz closure removes ~20% of global oil/LNG supply. Fertilizer prices up 30–40%. Iran's selective Hormuz reopening fragments the shipping order. Iraq's force majeure hits BP, TotalEnergies, and ExxonMobil. Over 2–6 weeks, expect oil above $100, accelerating food-price inflation, and pressure on European gas storage.

Sources: Al Jazeera; Al Jazeera; Bloomberg; Bloomberg; Reuters; Reuters; Reuters; Defense News; Long War Journal †; FT; Haaretz †

[Gulf States — Hezbollah Cells Disrupted, Drone Attacks Reported] ▲ **Escalating**

Parties: Iran-backed groups vs. UAE, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: Kuwait and UAE disrupted domestic Hezbollah cells. Hezbollah denied having Gulf operatives. Bahrain said a Patriot system intercepted a drone over residential areas on March 9. Missile and drone attacks targeted UAE, Kuwait, and Saudi Arabia. Saudi Arabia restarted Ras Tanura refinery after a drone attack.

Risk Assessment: Iran's proxy network activating across the Gulf. Direct attacks on energy infrastructure already disrupted production. Gulf sovereign and infrastructure risk premiums elevated through Q2.

Sources: Long War Journal †; Al Jazeera; Al Jazeera

[Israel Strikes Syria After Druze Clashes] ▬ **Ongoing**

Parties: Israel vs. Syria

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: Israel struck weapons sites and government infrastructure in Syria. Damascus condemned the strikes as an 'outrageous' assault on sovereignty.

Risk Assessment: Secondary front opens amid the Iran war. Damascus lacks capacity to retaliate. Monitor for sustained campaign vs. episodic action.

Source: BBC

ASIA

[Pakistan-Afghanistan Border Conflict] ▲ **Escalating**

Parties: Pakistan vs. Afghan Taliban

Region: Asia

Latest Development: Mass-casualty incident near Kabul on March 16 marked a significant escalation. Pakistan conducted bombardments inside Afghanistan. Taliban's foreign minister mobilized diplomatic contacts. UN's Richard

Bennett called for de-escalation.

Risk Assessment: Pakistan-Taliban rupture threatens South Asian stability. Cross-border strikes signal breakdown of post-withdrawal accommodation. Expect further escalation over 2–4 weeks absent mediation.

Sources: Crisis Group †; BBC; Hasht-e Subh Daily †

[Taiwan Strait — China Reduces Warplane Activity] ▼ **De-escalating**

Parties: China vs. Taiwan

Region: Asia

Latest Development: China reduced warplane sorties toward Taiwan in recent weeks. US intelligence assesses no invasion plan by 2027 despite continued buildup. Trump-Xi summit delayed by approximately one month.

Risk Assessment: Reduced PLA air activity likely reflects Beijing avoiding a two-front crisis. Taiwan flags concern over US missile stock depletion in the Gulf. Medium-term risk shifted rightward, not diminished.

Sources: Defense News; Fox News †; FT; SCMP †

EUROPE

[Ukraine-Russia War — Starlink Cutoff Enables Ukrainian Offensive] ▬ **Ongoing**

Parties: Ukraine vs. Russia

Region: Europe

Latest Development: Ukraine launched offensive operations after Musk cut Russian forces' Starlink connections in February. Russian commanders lost battlefield video and comms. Compulsory evacuation of children ordered from Sloviansk as Russians closed to 20km. Russia preparing spring-summer mechanized offensive. Ukraine deployed drone-defense units to five Gulf states in exchange for money and technology.

Risk Assessment: Starlink disruption gave Ukraine a tactical window. Russia's spring offensive preparations suggest the advantage may be temporary. Ukraine's Gulf drone-defense deployment is a remarkable strategic pivot. Eastern front likely intensifies over 4–8 weeks.

Sources: WSJ; The Guardian †; ISW †; Defense News; BBC

AFRICA

[Sudan Civil War — Famine Deepens as Fighting Continues] ▬ **Ongoing**

Parties: Sudanese Armed Forces vs. Rapid Support Forces

Region: Africa

Latest Development: Fighting continues across Darfur, Khartoum, and Kordofan. The UN classifies this as the world's largest displacement event. Aid access severely restricted. Famine confirmed in multiple areas.

Risk Assessment: No ceasefire prospects near-term. Gold and gum arabic supply chains affected. Watch for refugee spillover pressuring Egypt and Chad over 3–6 months.

Source: BBC

World Affairs

NEW **[Trump's Iran War Decision Driven by Outside Allies — Cabinet Stayed Muted]** Bloomberg reports outside allies partly motivated the war decision. White House team offered little pushback. Absence of internal dissent raises escalatory risk as White House debates Kharg Island operation. Policy volatility elevated for defense and energy.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[White House Weighs Seizing Iran's Kharg Island — 2,000+ Marines Deploying]** Pentagon ordered 2,000+ additional Marines to the Middle East. Kharg handles ~90% of Iranian crude exports. Seizure would eliminate Iran's revenue but commit US forces to holding territory under fire. Oil markets spike on any confirmation.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Iranian Man Charged After Attempting to Enter UK Nuclear Submarine Base]** An Iranian man and Romanian woman arrested at Britain's nuclear submarine base in Scotland. Police Scotland filed charges Thursday. Expanding Iranian intelligence operations against UK military infrastructure. Tightened security expected at allied installations across Europe.

Source: Al-Monitor †

NEW **[Japan and South Korea Close Ranks as Trump and Xi Both Apply Pressure]** Once-fierce rivals coordinating amid simultaneous pressure from Washington and Beijing. Combined coordination could accelerate supply-chain diversification from China over 12–24 months.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Modi Calls Iran's Pezeshkian — Stresses Need for Secure Shipping Lanes]** Phone call Saturday. Modi emphasized open shipping lanes. Pezeshkian called for "immediate cessation" of US-Israeli aggression. India positioning as neutral broker while protecting energy supply. Bilateral Hormuz deals give New Delhi leverage neither the US nor Europe holds.

Sources: Bloomberg; Al-Monitor †

NEW **[Austria Seeks €2B in Budget Cuts — Finance Minister Blames 'Dumb War']** Finance Minister Marterbauer said the country must find €1–2B in savings. Called the Iran conflict a "dumb war" threatening the outlook. Mirrors pressure building across smaller eurozone economies. Expect more peripheral EU austerity as the energy shock feeds through.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[UAE Orders Iranian State-Linked Hospital in Dubai Closed]** Three employees confirmed the closure to AFP. Another sign of deteriorating Iran-UAE ties. Dubai hosts significant Iranian business networks. Institutional decoupling could accelerate.

Source: Al-Monitor †

NEW **[Rheinmetall Plans to Take Over Germany's Delayed F126 Frigate Program]** Maritime Systems head confirmed a swift restart for the German Navy. Project currently behind schedule. Rheinmetall consolidating German defense-industrial capacity as naval prime. European defense equity premium likely sustained through 2026.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Trump-Xi Summit On Hold Until Iran War Ends — China Sees Stronger Hand]** *Late-March summit postponed as Iran dominates.* No reschedule until conflict concludes. Trump said "five or six weeks." CNN

reports Beijing believes delay strengthens its position. Previously: Late-March summit postponed as Iran dominates. China's soybean purchases stalled. CNN reported Beijing sees Trump entangled. Indefinite delay freezes tariff-pause framework. China accumulates leverage with each week of US distraction.

Sources: Politico; CNN; SCMP †

DAY 2 **[Iran Still Refuses Hormuz Talks — But Offers Bilateral Passage Deals]** *Tehran unwilling to discuss reopening while under attack.* Now offering bilateral transit to Japan, joining India. Strategy fragments blockade into country-by-country deals. Previously: Western intel assessed regime not close to falling. Iran unwilling to discuss Hormuz while under attack. Bilateral deals give Tehran leverage and divide potential coalition members. Shipping insurance differentials between covered and uncovered nations will widen.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Israel Strikes Tehran and Reportedly Natanz on Eid — New Supreme Leader Still Hidden]** *Al-Monitor reported a US-Israeli strike on Natanz. Mojtaba Khamenei had not appeared publicly.* Fresh strikes on Tehran Saturday. Continued absence raises succession-stability questions. Previously: Al-Monitor reported a US-Israeli strike on Natanz. Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei had not appeared publicly. Nuclear facility targeting escalates the proliferation dimension. IAEA access and verification timelines become critical.

Sources: Al-Monitor †; Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[Taiwan Alarm Over US Missile Stocks — War Expenditure Drains Indo-Pacific Reserves]** *Weapons expended in the Gulf would be crucial in any China conflict.* FT reports growing concern in Taipei over unsustainable consumption rates. Previously: Weapons expended in the Gulf would be crucial in early phases of any China conflict. Norway's defense minister warned NATO must hold all flanks. Munitions depletion is China's strategic windfall. Expect accelerated Taiwan orders for asymmetric defense systems over 6–12 months.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Panama Canal at Max Capacity — Preparing Daily LNG Slots]** *Canal operating at 36–38 vessels per day.* Now preparing one LNG slot per day, up from four per month. LNG tanker demand surging from US ports. Previously: Canal operating at top capacity. LNG tanker demand surging from US ports. One LNG slot per day being prepared, up from four per month. Canal becomes critical bottleneck as LNG reroutes from Hormuz. Slot pricing power shifts to canal authority.

Source: Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[Putin Pledges Loyalty to Iran — But Iranian Sources Say Help Is Hollow]** *Kremlin pledged friendship.* Iranian sources said they received little real help. Gap between rhetoric and material support widening. Previously: Kremlin pledged friendship. Iranian sources said they received little real help. Gap between rhetoric and material support widening. Russia preserving resources for Ukraine while extracting positioning from optics. Exposes limits of the Iran-Russia axis under stress.

Source: Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[IRGC Rebuilt Hezbollah's Command With Iranian Officers — Now Waging War]** *IRGC plugged command gaps with Iranian officers after Israel decimated Hezbollah leadership.* Restructured for the current conflict. Previously: Iran's Revolutionary Guards plugged gaps with Iranian officers after Israel decimated Hezbollah leadership. Restructured for the current conflict. IRGC-embedded command means striking Hezbollah leadership now means striking Iranian officers directly. Escalates the bilateral dimension.

Source: Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[Merz Doubles Down on MAGA Criticism — Still Plans Trump Engagement]** *German Chancellor distanced himself from Trump's base.* Balancing act reflects broader European ambivalence toward Washington during

the Iran war. Previously: German Chancellor distanced himself from Trump's base. Plans continued engagement despite public criticism. Rhetorical distance from MAGA plays domestically but limits Berlin's influence on Iran policy. Transatlantic defense coordination strained.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Norway Warns NATO: Hold All Flanks as US Focuses on Middle East]** *Norwegian defense minister warned the alliance must avoid retrenchment.* US Middle East focus creating gaps in European posture. Previously: Norwegian defense minister said the alliance must avoid retrenchment. US Middle East focus creating gaps in European posture. European defense spending acceleration becomes more urgent with each week of US distraction. Arctic and North Atlantic concerns well-founded.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Iran's Grain Ship Exemptions Continue — Food Supply 'Pain Point']** *Tehran allowed agricultural vessels to transit.* FT confirms ongoing exemptions. Signals domestic food-supply pressures shaping Iran's Hormuz strategy. Previously: Tehran allowed agricultural vessels to transit. Agriculture a 'pain point' since the de facto blockade. Food exemptions reveal regime vulnerability — a lever for negotiations. Selective enforcement creates arbitrage for commodity traders with grain exposure.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Iran's 10 Million Rial Banknote Circulates as Hard-Currency Demand Surges]** *Highest-ever denomination bill introduced.* Iranians queuing for hard currency as strikes fuel economic panic. Previously: Highest-ever denomination bill introduced. Iranians queuing for hard currency. New Supreme Leader has not appeared publicly. High-denomination issuance during conflict signals dollarization pressure. Rial trajectory mirrors historical wartime currency crises.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Zombie Ship Using Scrapped Vessel Identity Exits Hormuz]** *A vessel assumed a scrapped gas carrier's identity to transit Hormuz.* Bloomberg confirms evasion strategies evolving. Previously: A vessel assumed the identity of a scrapped gas carrier to transit Hormuz. Bloomberg confirmed strategies are evolving. Identity spoofing complicates maritime enforcement and insurance underwriting. P&I clubs will tighten verification across all Hormuz-adjacent shipping.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Iranian Navy LPG Escort Confirmed by Crew — Bilateral Passage Expanding]** *Senior officer onboard confirmed Iran gave passage after Tehran-New Delhi negotiations.* India and Japan now have de facto Hormuz access Europe lacks. Previously: Senior officer onboard confirmed Iran gave passage after Tehran-New Delhi negotiations. Follows similar offer to Japan. Crew-level confirmation validates bilateral transit as operational. Two-tier Hormuz access is now reality.

Source: Bloomberg

Art & Auction Intelligence

NEW **[Christie's Routes Early Van Gogh to Hong Kong — March 27 Sale]** A Girl in a Wood heads to auction in Hong Kong, bypassing New York. Christie's cites Asian dominance of the Van Gogh market. In 2024, Moored Boats sold in Hong Kong for $32M. Routing confirms Hong Kong as primary Impressionist marketplace targeting mainland Chinese wealth. Expect further lot migration from New York over 12–18 months.

Source: The Art Newspaper

NEW **[Sam Doyle Painting May Set New Price Peak at Outsider Art Fair]** Works by the Gullah artist from the Bob Roth collection headline the Outsider Art Fair in New York. Fair runs through March 22. A new Doyle record would confirm sustained appetite for African-American vernacular art, outperforming broader contemporary indices since 2022.

Sources: Artnet News; The Art Newspaper

DAY 2 **[Whitney Biennial — CFGNY Collective Emerges as Breakout Amid Tepid Reception]** *Critics called the show 'for the faint-hearted.'* Artnet highlights fashion-art collective CFGNY as "captivating New York" across three simultaneous shows. Previously: Critics called the show 'for the faint-hearted.' Mixed reviews dominated opening coverage. Biennial breakout artists historically see 2–3x gallery pricing within 18 months. CFGNY's multi-venue presence positions it for accelerated market attention.

Sources: Artnet News; Hyperallergic

DAY 2 **[Cecily Brown Serpentine Show — Artsy Profiles 7 Adjacent Artists Ahead of March 27 Opening]** *'Picture Making' opens March 27. Follows acclaimed 2022 Met exhibition.* Chief curator says the paintings "seem to vibrate in a perpetual present tense." Previously: 'Picture Making' opens March 27 at Serpentine. Follows acclaimed 2022 Met exhibition. Pre-opening media saturation suggests strong collector traffic. Brown's secondary market may see upward pressure on mid-career works from the 2000s.

Source: Artsy

Design, UX & Industrial

NEW **[Miller Hull Completes Mass-Timber Library in Redmond, Oregon]** Two-story building more than doubles the previous library's footprint. Designed with Steele Associates for Deschutes Public Library. Mass timber migrating into permanent civic infrastructure. Public library commissions signal municipal comfort with the material system.

Source: ArchDaily

NEW **[Raza Zahid's Papercrete Installation — Recycled Waste as Branch-Like Lattice]** Hand-formed papercrete branches create a porous, tree-like spatial structure. Project turns recycled paper waste into a living installation. Signals growing appetite among galleries and design fairs for waste-derived structural media ahead of Milan Design Week.

Source: DesignBoom

NEW **[Verge Select Completes Weathering-Steel Painting Studio — Grey County, Ontario]** Three Corten volumes fuse into a secluded forest retreat for painter Janna Watson. Materiality designed to age into the landscape. Weathering steel gaining ground in bespoke creative retreats. Artist-as-client briefs define material trends 2–3 years ahead of residential mainstream.

Source: Dezeen

NEW **[In Sinu Architectes — Woodland House Frames 'Living Tableaux' Near Fontainebleau]** French studio renovated and extended a home on the forest edge. Large windows frame painting-like views. Named Maison de l'Orée. French rural-renovation briefs increasingly prioritise scenographic framing over expansion. Post-pandemic demand pattern now entrenched in Île-de-France's second-home belt.

Source: Dezeen

NEW **[DesignBoom Announces 'Room for Dreams' Takeover — Milan Design Week 2026]** Site-specific installation takes over ME Milan Il Duca hotel during Salone. Publication moves from digital platform to physical exhibition. Design-media brands monetising through live activations rather than advertising. Follows Dezeen's gallery model — signals media-as-curator consolidation ahead of Milan's April calendar.

Source: DesignBoom

NEW **[Lore Bath House Opens as Community Hub — Downtown Manhattan]** Urban sauna positioned as a reconstitution of the long-lost community gathering point. Design Milk frames it as a neighbourhood agora. Urban bathhouse concepts proliferating in US gateway cities. The model blends hospitality, retail, and community — a format PE-backed wellness platforms are scaling.

Source: Design Milk †

DAY 2 **[Kéré Architecture Healthcare Centre, Burundi — Construction Underway]** *3,000 sqm complex with ten pavilions connected by zigzag hillside road.* First phase scheduled for completion this year. Commissioned by NGO Ineza Clinic. Previously: 3,000 sqm complex with ten pavilions connected by zigzag hillside road. Regional materials and community-based construction approach. Construction confirmation is the material update. Kéré's post-Pritzker healthcare model — NGO client, local labour, regional materials — is being watched by development-finance institutions.

Source: ArchDaily

DAY 2 **[Nike England World Cup Kit — Texture-Engineered Fabric Detailed]** *Nike unveiled 'unapologetically English' kit with embedded graphic elements.* Flags, lions, and stars engineered into fabric rather than printed. Previously: Nike unveiled 'unapologetically English' World Cup kit with embedded graphic elements in texture-engineered fabric. Engineered-in graphics eliminate print layers. If performance data holds, expect Nike to extend the technique across World Cup portfolio.

Source: Dezeen

DAY 2 **[UIA 2026 Barcelona — Multi-Venue Mediterranean Programme Confirmed]** *World Congress of Architects returns 28 June–2 July.* Congress unfolds across multiple sites along the seafront. ~10,000 participants from 130+ countries expected. Previously: World Congress of Architects returns 28 June–2 July. Six thematic 'Becomings' structure the programme. Distributed-venue model mirrors Venice Biennale strategy. Hospitality and travel sectors should anticipate a 10,000-delegate influx late June.

Source: ArchDaily

DAY 4 **[OMA New Museum Expansion — Gioni's 'New Humans' Exhibition Detailed]** *OMA completed angular expansion at 235 Bowery.* Inaugural exhibition curated by Gioni recalls 'visions of humanity that are both utopian and monstrous.' Doubles the museum's footprint. Previously: OMA completed angular expansion at 235 Bowery. Inaugural 'New Humans' exhibition curated by Gioni. Dezeen and DesignBoom both profiled the opening. Exhibition scale positions the expanded New Museum as a serious rival to Whitney and MoMA PS1 for contemporary programming.

Sources: DesignBoom; Dezeen

DAY 4 **[Giertz Laundry Chair — $750K Raised, Early Bird at $899]** *Simone Giertz's swivel-arm Laundry Chair launched on Kickstarter.* Solid hardwood frame. Cotton corduroy upholstery. Ships flatpack, expected November. Previously: Simone Giertz's swivel-arm Laundry Chair launched on Kickstarter for 'not dirty, not clean' clothes. Campaign went viral from Instagram prototyping series. $750K in days validates creator-to-DTC furniture. Premium materials at $899 suggest margin headroom. Watch for licensing interest from contract-furniture players.

Source: Core77

AI & Technology

NEW **[SoftBank's Son Says Ohio Data Center Will Channel $500B Into Single Campus]** Gas-plant-powered development dwarfs prior AI infrastructure commitments. Ohio power grid, construction labor, and gas supply chains face acute demand pressure. Even discounting Son's historically aspirational figures, a gas-powered mega-campus signals AI infrastructure at a new order of magnitude. Competing hyperscalers may accelerate site announcements.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[WordPress.com Lets AI Agents Draft, Edit, and Publish Posts via MCP]** Claude, ChatGPT, and Cursor can now manage content on WordPress sites. All actions require user approval. WordPress powers 43% of websites globally. With 43% web share, WordPress becomes the largest surface for agentic AI content. Machine-generated web content will accelerate sharply.

Sources: TechCrunch; MLQ.ai †

NEW **[OpenClaw's Rise Sparks Concern That AI Models Are Becoming Commodities]** Huang dedicated a major GTC keynote segment to OpenClaw. Platform proved "fully autonomous AI can be run at home." Rapid adoption shows how quickly expensive models commoditize. Model commoditization compresses frontier-lab margins. Value shifts to distribution and domain-specific fine-tuning. PE-backed AI infrastructure plays face repricing risk.

Source: CNBC

NEW **[Pentagon Memo Accelerates AI Battlefield Integration Around Maven]** Policy memo directs DoD to put AI decision-making at the heart of linking sensors and shooters. Palantir's AI system won key status. Maven's elevation cements Palantir's defense franchise. Defense AI budgets tilt toward sensor-fusion and autonomous targeting over 12 months.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Anthropic Files Sworn Declarations Pushing Back on Pentagon's 'Unacceptable Risk' Claim]** *DoD told Anthropic the two sides were close to agreement one week before Trump ended the relationship.* Two declarations argue the government relies on technical misunderstandings. Previously: DoD told Anthropic the two sides were close to agreement one week before Trump ended the relationship. Court filings revealed the 'unacceptable risk' designation. If the court sides with Anthropic, it limits executive authority to blacklist AI vendors on national security grounds. Enterprise buyers watching for contract-risk signals.

Sources: TechCrunch; Wired

DAY 2 **[White House AI Framework Faces Legal Ambiguity on State Preemption]** *Seven-point plan urges Congress to preempt state AI laws.* Silent on already-enacted state laws. Effectiveness limited without congressional action. Previously: Seven-point plan urges Congress to preempt state AI laws. Emphasizes innovation over regulation. Shifts child safety burden to parents. Without legislation, the framework is aspirational. State AG enforcement remains the live risk through the election cycle.

Sources: PitchBook; TechCrunch

DAY 2 **[OpenAI Confirms 'AI Researcher' Is Its New Grand Challenge]** *OpenAI pivoted to building an autonomous agent for independent complex problem-solving.* Refocusing research and resources into the effort. Previously: OpenAI announced pivot to building an autonomous agent it calls an 'AI researcher,' capable of independent complex problem-solving. Frames OpenAI's competitive narrative for a potential 2026 IPO. Autonomous research agents could compress R&D cycles in pharma, materials, and engineering.

Source: MIT Technology Review

DAY 2 **[Warren, Blumenthal Probe Whether Nvidia-Groq $20B Deal Evades Merger Review]** *Senate probe targets whether licensing structure avoids FTC review.* Senators question whether it illegally circumvents scrutiny. Previously: Senate probe targets whether deal structure avoids FTC review. Probe gains weight now that LPU chip is public. If licensing-vs-acquisition is deemed an antitrust workaround, it reshapes tech M&A structuring broadly.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Accel's Mathew Predicts 'Fewer Winners' as AI Bubble Tendencies Persist]** *Accel partner flagged 'bubble tendencies' in AI venture market.* AI startups took 41% of $128B raised on Carta last year — a record share. Previously: Accel partner Arun Mathew flagged 'bubble tendencies' in AI venture market. 41% VC concentration in AI is historically abnormal. LPs should stress-test AI portfolio exposure for commodity-model risk. Vintage 2025–2026 funds face binary outcomes.

Sources: Bloomberg; TechCrunch

Economic & Business Intelligence

NEW **[Trump Floats 'Winding Down' Iran War — Pentagon Sends More Troops]** Trump said the US is "very close" to meeting military objectives. Pentagon simultaneously ordered thousands more Marines to the region. Rhetorical de-escalation without operational follow-through. Oil markets stay elevated until Hormuz physically reopens.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

NEW **[US Says Iran's Ability to Threaten Hormuz 'Degraded' After Coastline Strikes]** CENTCOM confirmed destruction of Iranian coastal facilities. Iran remains unwilling to discuss reopening. Physical degradation necessary but insufficient to reopen Hormuz. Tanker insurers unlikely to ease war-risk premiums near-term.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

NEW **[WSJ's Ip — Fed's Next Move 'Might Be to Raise Rates']** Greg Ip writes the Fed is officially focused on cuts but "the vibes have changed." A hike is now thinkable given stubborn inflation and Iran. Ip is the most-watched Fed whisperer. This column shifts consensus framing. Expect 2-year Treasury yields under upward pressure Monday.

Source: WSJ

NEW **[Some Oil Products Now Trading Above $200/Barrel — Physical Premium Widens]** Growing gap between futures and physical supply costs. Real-world consumer prices are worse than Brent suggests. Physical premiums above $200 signal extreme refinery-level supply stress. Margin compression will appear in Q1 earnings across industrials.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Fertilizer Shock Escalates as New Supply Risks Emerge Beyond Nitrogen]** Middle East war already disrupted nitrogen-based nutrients. Bloomberg reports a bigger threat emerging in another part of the fertilizer market. Fertilizer costs feed into food CPI with a 3–6 month lag. If nitrogen and potash/phosphate tighten simultaneously, EM food inflation could trigger social instability by H2 2026.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[OpenAI Plans to Nearly Double Workforce to 8,000 by Year-End]** Growth from 4,500 to 8,000 staff. FT reports the move aims to close gap with Anthropic. 78% headcount growth signals aggressive spending. Burn rate will test investor patience if revenue doesn't scale proportionally.

Sources: FT; Yahoo Finance Australia †

NEW **[Canada's Oil Producers in Line for C$90B Windfall From Iran War]** Rising crude prices boost Canadian export revenue. PM Carney seeks to leverage the windfall against Trump's trade wars. Production hurdles remain. Windfall strengthens Carney's fiscal position. Oil sands can't ramp quickly — net beneficiary but limited as swing supplier.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

NEW **[United Airlines CEO Warns of $175 Oil Scenario — Says Airline Is Ready]** Scott Kirby outlined worst-case fuel cost scenarios. Record travel demand currently offsets pressure. At $175 oil, jet fuel consumes 40%+ of airline operating budgets. Hedging positions and fuel surcharges become critical differentiators.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Qatar Investment Authority Eyes 10% Stake in Golden Goose]** QIA preparing to buy ~10% of the Italian sneaker maker. Golden Goose reported 2025 revenues of €734M, up 15% at constant currency. QIA deploying

into luxury brands during wartime signals category confidence. Golden Goose's 34% EBITDA margin validates premium sneaker as durable asset class.

Sources: Bloomberg; WWD

NEW **[Zegna Reports €1.9B Revenue — Flags Iran War Risk to 2026 Luxury Demand]** Net profit rose 20% to €109.5M. Management warned Middle East developments "increased uncertainty" on luxury demand. First major luxury house to explicitly cite Iran war as demand risk. Expect LVMH, Kering, and Hermès to echo similar caution.

Source: FashionUnited †

NEW **[BoE Communication Revamp Criticized for Fueling UK Bond Rout]** New policy publishing individual rate-setter views drew blame. Hawkish pivot amplified gilt selloff. BoE's transparency experiment backfired during a supply-side shock. Gilt volatility persists until Bailey clarifies guidance.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

NEW **[Flash PMIs Due Tuesday — First Hard Look at Iran War's Economic Damage]** Provisional US and European purchasing managers' surveys for March land this week. First full month capturing war-related supply-chain disruption. Tuesday's flash PMIs are the most consequential release of the week. Sub-50 manufacturing in Europe would confirm recession fears.

Source: WSJ

NEW **[Morgan Stanley's Shalett — US Recession Probability 'Less Than 30%']** Lisa Shalett said recession potential remains below 30%. Assessment comes as war uncertainty clouds the outlook. Sub-30% is relatively constructive given the backdrop. Number shifts fast if oil stays above $110 through Q2.

Source: CNBC

NEW **[EU Proposes Lower Gas Storage Targets and Demand Reduction Measures]** Commission urged member states to reduce energy demand. Separately proposed lowering storage targets. Both signal managed scarcity. Lowering targets admits pre-war filling levels are unachievable. Demand destruction becomes official EU policy. European industrials face cost uncertainty through winter 2026–27.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Markets Price ~75% Chance of Fed Hike by September — Total Reversal in Five Days]** *Better-than-even odds of July hike had emerged five days prior.* Probability strengthened further. Bond traders fully erased 2026 easing expectations. Previously: Better-than-even odds of a July hike had emerged. Five days earlier, markets had firmly expected cuts. Complete erasure of 2026 easing in one week is historically unusual. Equity multiples face sustained compression if hike pricing holds.

Sources: Kitco/Reuters; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[S&P 500 Posts Fourth Straight Weekly Decline — 10-Year Yield Hits August Highs]** *Major benchmarks at six-month lows. Russell 2000 entered correction.* 10-year yield reached 4.328%. Truist's Lerner warned yields above 4.3% pressure equities further. Previously: Major benchmarks dropped to six-month lows. Russell 2000 entered correction territory. Fourth consecutive weekly decline with rising yields is toxic. Tuesday's PMIs are the next catalyst.

Sources: Kitco/Reuters; CNBC

DAY 2 **[Blackstone Private Credit Loss Underscored by Goldman's Solomon Warning]** *BCRED posted first monthly loss since 2022.* Solomon's shareholder letter warned the credit cycle "has not been repealed." Previously: Blackstone's flagship private credit fund posted first monthly loss since 2022. Goldman's warning plus Blackstone's loss marks a sentiment inflection for the $1.8T private credit market. LP redemption queues likely to lengthen.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[UK Gilts Under Sustained Pressure — Hawkish BoE, Borrowing Overshoot Compound]** *10-year gilt hit 5%, highest since 2008.* February borrowing hit £14.3B above forecast. Hedge fund gilt trades unwinding. Previously: 10-year gilt yield hit 5%, highest since 2008. Markets priced 80bp of BoE hikes. Gilt market in negative feedback loop: higher yields → larger debt servicing → wider deficits → higher yields. Sterling fixed-income uninvestable until BoE clarifies.

Sources: FT; FT

DAY 2 **[Reeves Faces 'Very Difficult Budget' — Treasury Foresees Recession Hints]** *Rising gilt yields eroding fiscal headroom.* FT reports Treasury now foresees a "very difficult Budget." Selloff could cost more than a tenth of her fiscal buffer. Previously: Rising gilt yields eroding fiscal headroom. February borrowing exceeded forecast. Fiscal rules effectively dead if gilt yields persist above 5%. Stagflation is now the base case for UK H2 2026.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Iraq Force Majeure Confirmed — Crude Exports Blocked by Hormuz Disruption]** *Baghdad invoked force majeure on all foreign-operated oilfields.* Directly impacts BP, Shell, ExxonMobil. Previously: Baghdad invoked force majeure as Hormuz blocks crude exports. Directly impacts BP, Shell, ExxonMobil. Force majeure triggers contractual protections but freezes revenue. Extended disruption shifts Iraq's fiscal position toward crisis within weeks.

Source: Reuters

DAY 2 **[ECB Hawks Intensify — Nagel Says April Hike Needed If Prices Worsen]** *Makhlouf said April hike possible. Villeroy declared ECB 'totally determined.'* Nagel argued ECB must prevent inflation surge from becoming entrenched. Previously: Makhlouf said April hike possible. Villeroy declared ECB 'totally determined.' Traders priced 50%+ for April. Three Governing Council members now publicly discussing April hike. Consensus forming faster than after Russia's Ukraine invasion.

Sources: Reuters; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[India's RBI Reserve Burn Continues — Oil Import Costs the Primary Channel]** *Over $20B spent in March defending the rupee.* FT confirmed oil import costs as primary driver. Previously: Over $20B spent in March alone. Reserve burn rate deemed unsustainable beyond months. At current burn rate, RBI faces hard choice between rupee defense and growth support within 8–10 weeks.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Dallas Fed Hormuz Model — 2.9pp Q2 GDP Hit If Closure Persists]** *Dallas Fed modeled a Hormuz closure through June.* Result: 2.9 percentage point annualized reduction in Q2 global GDP. Previously: Dallas Fed published scenario analysis. Vanguard said oil would need ~$150 for rest of 2026 to trigger full recession. 2.9pp contraction would be the largest exogenous shock since COVID. Global recession probability rises materially each week Hormuz stays closed.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[First SPR Barrels Set to Flow — Iranian Oil Sales License Confirmed]** *SPR release announced alongside Treasury license for stranded Iranian oil.* First oil from Trump's 172M-barrel emergency release set to flow soon. Previously: US issued license permitting sale of stranded Iranian oil on vessels. SPR release announced. SPR plus stranded Iranian oil are stopgap measures. Combined volume insufficient to replace lost Hormuz flows for more than weeks.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[EU Energy Chief Orders Early Gas Filling — Competitive Bidding Risk Flagged]** *Commission told member states to start filling immediately.* Goal: avoid summer price spikes from competitive bidding. Previously: Commission told member states to start filling immediately to avoid competitive summer bidding. Early filling with lower

targets is a managed retreat. TTF gas prices likely elevated through summer as 27 members compete for diminished LNG cargoes.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[ECB Bank Inquiry Confirmed — Asking About Client and Operational Fallout]** *ECB began asking lenders about conflict impact.* Energy-exposed loan books under closest scrutiny. Previously: ECB began asking lenders about conflict impact on operations and clients. Supervisory data-gathering at this pace typically precedes capital buffer guidance. European bank stocks face overhang until assessment concludes.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Diesel at $5+/Gallon — Ripple Effects 'Worth Watching']** *US diesel surpassed $5 for only the second time in history.* Powers trucking, agriculture, construction. Amplifies inflation beyond headline gasoline. Previously: US diesel surpassed $5 for only the second time in history. Diesel is the backbone of goods movement. At $5+, trucking margins compress and freight costs pass to retail within 4–6 weeks.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[UK Energy Price Cap Surge Confirmed at 20% — Cornwall Insight Forecast]** *Cornwall Insight forecast 20% summer price cap surge.* Typical bill rises £332/year in July. Previously: Cornwall Insight forecast 20% summer price cap surge. Rising gas costs the driver. £332/year increase hits in July at peak political sensitivity for Starmer. Combined with rising mortgage rates, UK households face worst squeeze since 2022.

Sources: Bloomberg; BBC

DAY 2 **[UK Mortgage Rate Rises 'Very Likely' — Lenders Rapidly Repricing]** *Lenders rapidly repricing fixed-rate deals.* Gilt selloff and inflation fears driving the adjustment. Previously: Lenders rapidly repricing fixed-rate deals. Gilt selloff and inflation fears driving the adjustment. UK housing faces a double hit: rising rates and falling real incomes. Transaction volumes decline sharply in Q2.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Airline Crisis Deepens — Qantas CEO Assures Fuel Supply Into April]** *FT called it the biggest airline crisis since the pandemic.* Qantas CEO memo confirmed fuel supplies "assured well into next month." Narrow window. Previously: Middle East war unleashing severe disruption. Fears of jet fuel shortage rattling carriers. 'Well into April' is a narrow window. If Hormuz disruption persists, route cuts become unavoidable. Asia-Pacific carriers most exposed.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[FT — 'Iran War Will Scar the Global Economy']** *Markets had clung to thesis that Hormuz would reopen quickly. That narrative collapsed Friday.* IEA chief Birol called it "the greatest threat to global energy in history." Previously: Markets clung to thesis that Hormuz would reopen quickly. That narrative collapsed Friday. IEA's "greatest threat in history" framing is unprecedented. Six-month recovery timeline outlasts most portfolio hedging horizons.

Sources: FT; FT

DAY 2 **[EU Energy Squeeze Worsens — IEA Urges Working From Home, Slower Driving]** *Iranian attacks knocked out 17% of Qatar's LNG export capacity.* IEA called for consumer demand measures. Demand destruction now official policy. Previously: Iranian attacks knocked out 17% of Qatar's LNG export capacity. IEA chief called it the greatest threat to global energy in history. IEA behavioral demand reduction echoes 1970s crisis playbook. Energy-intensive manufacturers will accelerate relocation to the US where gas remains cheaper.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Global Rate Hike Cycle Taking Shape — All Major Central Banks Held and Warned]** *Fed, ECB, BoE, BoJ all held this week. All sounded cautious on inflation.* Bloomberg confirmed synchronized caution. Previously:

Fed, ECB, BoE, BoJ all held this week. All sounded cautious on inflation. SNB paused. Synchronized hawkish signaling across G7 is the most bearish macro setup since 2022. EM currencies and equities face outflow pressure as DM yields rise.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[BoC Hike Bets Mount — Hawkish Peer Messaging Reinforces Pricing]** *Traders pricing more aggressive BoC tightening.* Surging oil and hawkish peer messaging driving the repricing. Previously: Traders had begun pricing more aggressive BoC tightening. TSX confirmed full entry into correction. Canada's dual position as oil producer and inflation-sensitive economy creates a policy paradox. Hikes protect currency but risk choking non-energy sectors.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Ireland Upgrade Reinforced — Makhlouf Says Better Placed Than European Peers]** *S&P upgraded Ireland citing resilience despite trade upheaval.* Makhlouf said Ireland starts from a stronger base than many EU peers. Previously: S&P upgraded Ireland. Makhlouf said Ireland better placed than European peers to weather Iran war. Irish bonds may attract eurozone safe-haven flows. Tech-heavy FDI base provides some insulation from energy-intensive industry risk.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 3 **[Super Micro Shores Up Compliance After 33% Stock Rout]** *Co-founder Liaw indicted for diverting Nvidia servers to China. Resigned from board. Shares plunged 33%.* Company working to strengthen compliance. Previously: Liaw indicted for allegedly diverting billions in Nvidia servers to China. Resigned from board. SMCI shares plunged. SMCI faces potential debarment from government contracts. AI server supply chain scrutiny intensifies sector-wide.

Source: Bloomberg

Private Equity

NEW **[LLR Partners-Backed Viventium Acquires Perks4Care]** Deal extends Viventium's HR-tech footprint in healthcare staffing. Perks4Care is a caregiver rewards platform. Healthcare staffing remains a PE consolidation hotspot. Caregiver retention tools are high-demand bolt-ons as senior care labor shortages persist.

Source: PE Hub

NEW **[M&A's 'Hot New Normal' Faces Trump Regulatory Uncertainty]** M&A optimism prevails at New Orleans industry gathering. A prominent voice warns things are not normal in Washington. Analysts expect longer timelines on antitrust-sensitive transactions through 2026.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Private Credit Default Pace Expected to Continue Into 2026]** *Distressed exchanges dominated at 94% of defaults.* Morningstar DBRS confirmed 78% YoY increase in 2025. PIK and deferred interest rising across middle-market borrowers. Previously: Distressed exchanges dominated at 94% of defaults. PIK and deferred interest rising across middle-market borrowers. Default acceleration validates Goldman's Solomon warning. LPs in mid-market direct lending should prepare for more frequent markdowns through H1 2026.

Source: PitchBook

DAY 2 **[KKR and FiberCop Secure €1B From Ares for Telecom Exchange Buyback]** *FiberCop secured €1B from Ares alongside KKR.* Italy's biggest fixed-line network buying back telecom exchanges once part of Telecom Italia. Previously: FiberCop secured €1B from Ares alongside KKR to buy back telecom exchanges once part of Italy's Telecom Italia. Confirms private credit's role in infrastructure consolidation. KKR using Ares capital to reconsolidate legacy telecom assets signals continued European infra dealmaking.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Echelon Data Centres Owners Weigh Sale Options]** *Bloomberg reported Echelon owners considering selling part or all stakes.* Dublin-based; process at early stage. AI-driven demand ensures strong bidder interest. Previously: Bloomberg reported Echelon owners considering selling part or all stakes. Process at early stage. European data centre M&A remains white-hot. Any sale process will attract hyperscaler, sovereign, and infra-fund bidders.

Source: Bloomberg

Startups

NEW **[xAI Sends Engineers to Client Offices to Win Enterprise Deals From OpenAI]** Musk's AI lab deploys on-site technical teams to prospective corporate customers. Strategy targets clients using OpenAI and Anthropic. White-glove deployment mirrors Palantir's early playbook. Three-way xAI/OpenAI/Anthropic competition compresses switching costs and improves buyer leverage.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[AI Startups Captured 41% of Carta Venture Dollars in 2025 — Record Share]** $128B raised on Carta last year. AI took 41%. Early fund vintages show strong returns, though follow-on markups inflate IRR. LPs with >30% AI exposure should stress-test markdowns. A correction in AI valuations ripples across most growth-stage portfolios.

Source: TechCrunch

NEW **[Google Ventures Europe — AI Dominates Portfolio Strategy]** GV Europe sees white-collar work as a $20T addressable market vs. $2.5T for software alone. Acknowledged enterprise AI adoption slower than predicted. GV's $20T TAM framing signals how top-tier investors justify current valuations. Admission that adoption lags is a useful counterweight.

Source: MediaPost †

DAY 2 **[Halter Fundraise Details — Founders Fund Backs $2B Valuation]** *AI cow collar startup would double its valuation.* Bloomberg confirmed talks to raise at more than $2B. Thiel's Founders Fund backing the round. Previously: AI-powered cow collar startup would double its valuation. Thiel's Founders Fund backing the round. AgTech at $2B+ signals Founders Fund conviction that AI-hardware combos in primary industries can scale. Limited direct comps exist.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Accel's Mathew — 'Bubble Tendencies' With Fewer AI Winners Ahead]** *Arun Mathew calls current cycle a 'reinvention of work.'* Warned of market fallout with fewer winners. Previously: Arun Mathew calls current cycle a 'reinvention of work.' Warns of market fallout. Productivity gains concentrating in fewer companies. Public caution from a senior Accel partner signals to LPs that even bullish VCs see concentration risk.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Weekly VC Rounds — Cybersecurity and Privacy Dominate Again]** *Security and privacy startups dominated this week's largest US deals.* Deal sizes smaller than recent weeks. Previously: Security and privacy startups dominated this week's largest US deals. AI infrastructure, biotech, and robotics also attracted significant funding. Deal size compression amid geopolitical uncertainty suggests capital rotating toward defensive sectors. Cybersecurity prominence reflects wartime enterprise spending.

Source: Crunchbase News †

DAY 3 **[Kalshi Temporarily Banned in Nevada Amid Regulatory Battle]** *Prediction market raised $1B+ at $22B valuation.* Nevada issued a temporary ban. Latest escalation in the fight over prediction markets' legal status. Previously: Prediction market raised $1B+ at $22B valuation. Judge signed restraining order blocking certain contracts. Regulatory friction mounting. State-level bans add regulatory surface area beyond federal courts. At $22B, multi-jurisdiction compliance challenges could delay growth.

Source: TechCrunch

DAY 5 **[Swarmer's 1,000% Surge — Defense-AI Fad Deepens]** *AI drone software maker's shares jumped 520% on first trading day.* Bloomberg called the debut 'a newfound investor appetite at the intersection of geopolitics, defense, and AI.' Previously: AI drone software maker hit best US debut performance in nearly a year. Shares jumped 520% first trading day alone. Bloomberg's 'fad' framing is deliberate. Tiny defense-AI stocks draw retail momentum. Watch for lockup expiry and insider selling.

Source: Bloomberg

IPO & Exit Climate

DAY 2 **[Russell 2000 Correction Deepens — First US Benchmark to Break]** *Russell 2000 fell into correction as oil and slowdown fears hit hardest.* Small caps especially sensitive to energy costs and deceleration. Previously: Russell 2000 fell into correction as oil prices and slowdown fears hit hardest. S&P 500 dropped to six-month lows. Small-cap correction compresses the viable IPO universe. Sub-$2B growth companies face worst pricing since late 2022. Expect pipeline deferrals through Q2.

Source: CNBC

DAY 2 **[Trend Signal — Private Credit Cracks Widen as Exit Windows Narrow Further]** *War bifurcated the IPO window: defense clearing, growth stalled.* BCRED posted first loss since 2022. Morningstar DBRS flagged 78% default acceleration. Russell 2000 in correction. Previously: War bifurcated the IPO window: defense and asset-backed clearing; growth stalled. Blackstone confirmed private credit stress emerging. LP liquidity under pressure from frozen IPO windows and private credit stress. Defense remains the lone clearing sector through Q2.

Sources: Bloomberg; PitchBook

Real Estate & Property

NEW **[Mortgage Rates Hit 6.22% — Highest Level of 2026]** Iran war uncertainty and energy-driven inflation pushed rates higher. Spring buying season faces affordability erosion. Rate trajectory hostage to Iran war duration. Residential transaction volumes likely compressed through Q2.

Source: Realtor.com

NEW **[Private Credit Faces Rising Defaults and Surging Withdrawal Requests]** Defaults rose last year. Fund withdrawal requests surged in recent weeks. Some fund shares dropped 50%+. BCRED posted first monthly loss since 2022. CRE-exposed private credit funds face sharpest scrutiny. Redemption queues could force distressed asset sales. LPs should monitor gate provisions over 60–90 days.

Sources: Law360; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[NextEra's 10 GW Gas Expansion Gets Trump Approval — Data Center Demand Cited]** *NextEra announced plans for up to 10 GW of gas-fired generation.* Trump formally approved. Texas and Pennsylvania sites to meet soaring data center power demand. Previously: NextEra announced plans for up to 10 GW of gas-fired generation; data center boom cited as driver. Largest single gas-generation expansion in years. Industrial land near planned TX/PA sites will see near-term premium.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Diesel Prices — Bloomberg Flags 'Real Concern' for Economy]** *Iran war pushed diesel past $5/gallon.* Outsized ripple effects through construction, trucking, and cold storage. Previously: Iran war pushed diesel past $5/gallon, levels last seen during Russia's 2022 Ukraine invasion. ~20% of trucking operating costs. Diesel is the transmission mechanism from geopolitics to CRE operating costs. Industrial REITs with NNN leases partially insulated; those bearing opex are not.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Activist Litt Formally Withdraws First Industrial REIT Board Nomination]** *Litt had nominated himself to First Industrial's board.* Bloomberg confirmed withdrawal. Said he can push for change from outside. Previously: Litt had nominated himself to First Industrial Realty Trust's board; withdrew citing ability to advocate from outside. Withdrawal signals pivot to public campaign or larger stake accumulation. Activist pressure on industrial REIT capital allocation is not over.

Source: Bloomberg

Alternative Assets

NEW **[Bicester Collection — Full-Price Sales Up 35%, Pivots to Experiential Luxury]** Current-season collections rose 35% YoY in 2025. 70% of luxury leaders identify experiential luxury as the leading trend. Belmont Park Village on Long Island is the first US site. 35% full-price growth validates the experiential pivot at luxury outlet villages. US expansion via Belmont Park signals confidence in the American high-spender segment.

Source: WWD

Operational Calendar

CONFIRMED EVENTS

March 19, 2026 — ECB Holds Deposit Rate at 2.00%

Governing Council left deposit facility rate at 2.00%, main refinancing rate at 2.15%, marginal lending at 2.40%. Lagarde held press conference.

Source: Forex Factory †

March 19, 2026 — Bank of England Rate Decision — Hold

BoE kept rates unchanged. Governor Bailey advised caution on potential hikes.

Source: Forex Factory †

March 19, 2026 — Swiss National Bank, Riksbank, BoJ Rate Decisions

SNB, Riksbank, and Bank of Japan all announced rate decisions on 'Super Thursday.' All expected to hold.

Sources: Mortgage News Daily †; CNBC

March 19, 2026 — U.S. Weekly Jobless Claims — 205K

Initial claims came in at 205,000. Philadelphia Fed manufacturing index also released.

Source: Mortgage News Daily †

March 19, 2026 — U.S. Treasury Month-End Supply Announcement

$69B 2-year, $70B 5-year, $44B 7-year notes, $28B reopened 2-year FRNs, $19B reopened 10-year TIPS.

Source: Mortgage News Daily †

March 19, 2026 — U.S. New Home Sales and Wholesale Inventories (Delayed)

January new home sales plunged 17.6%. Wholesale inventories fell 0.5%.

Source: Mortgage News Daily †

CONTEMPORARY ART SPOTLIGHT

The Benin Bronzes — Zurich's Museum Rietberg Returns 11 Objects to Nigeria

The repatriation of Benin Bronzes — thousands of sculptures looted by British forces in 1897 — remains one of the defining cultural-property debates of the 21st century. Zurich's Museum Rietberg transferred ownership of 11 to Nigeria. Nine will physically remain in Switzerland under loan.

1897 BRITISH LOOTING · THOUSANDS OF OBJECTS DISPERSED GLOBALLY · BRITISH MUSEUM, ETHNOLOGISCHES MUSEUM BERLIN, MUSEUM RIETBERG ZURICH

[Why it matters] The Benin Bronzes are the central test case for Western museums confronting colonial-era acquisitions. Germany transferred legal ownership of hundreds to Nigeria in 2022. Zurich's approach — ownership shifts while physical custody remains — is becoming the template. For collectors, provenance scrutiny on West African objects will only intensify.

[Current peg] Museum Rietberg transferred ownership of 11 Benin Bronzes to Nigeria. Nine remain in Switzerland. Extends the restitution wave after Germany's 2022 handover.

[Historical context] In 1897, British forces seized thousands of brass and bronze sculptures from the Kingdom of Benin. Objects dispersed to museums across Europe and North America. Produced by Edo craftsmen over centuries, they served as records of royal life. Germany's 2022 restitution pressured institutions from London to Zurich. The British Museum cites legal restrictions under the British Museum Act.

[One thing to know] The Rietberg model — transferring legal ownership while retaining physical custody through loan agreements — is becoming the European museum template. Collectors should expect provenance due diligence on Benin-kingdom material to become market standard.

Source: The Art Newspaper

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† Source not yet in our verified index. Accuracy has been checked programmatically but editorial vetting of this outlet is pending.

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